

Not Just Mimics: Study Suggests Parrots Use Names Like Humans Do

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Parrots are the comedians of the animal world, famous for **mimicking** everything from doorbells to swear words. But could their chatter be more than just imitation? A new study published in PLOS ONE suggests that parrots may use names in ways strikingly similar to humans identifying specific individuals, not just general groups.

Lauryn Benedict, a biology professor at the University of Northern Colorado, took an **unconventional** approach. Instead of trekking through rainforests to record wild parrots, she and her colleagues tapped into the ManyParrots project, a global network that gathers surveys and audio **recordings** from parrot owners. They analyzed data from more than 889 parrots, focusing on 413 **recordings** that included name use. In 88 cases, the birds appeared to use a name as a label for a particular person or animal. For example, a parrot might say "John" specifically when John entered the room, rather than using the word for any human.

"We cannot conclude that they are **analogous** to human names both because animal signals are often so different and because we don't understand the full intent behind the signals," cautioned Christine Dahlin of the University of Pittsburgh at Johnstown, a co-author on the study. Still, the evidence is compelling. The researchers found that parrots don't just copy names; they adapt them for different social purposes. Some birds repeatedly said their own name as a way of attracting attention akin to a child shouting "Look at me!" This flexibility suggests that parrots possess both the **cognitive** abilities and **vocal skills** to use names in a variety of contexts, possibly even to refer to someone who isn't present.

The findings open a window into the complex social lives of these birds. Differences between species and even individual birds raise new questions about how and why animals use vocal signals to navigate relationships. While we can't yet say Polly knows your name the way your best friend does, the line between mimicry and meaningful communication just got a little blurrier.

Word Treasure

mimicking -- Copying sounds or actions, often without understanding their meaning.

unconventional -- Unusual or different from the usual way of doing something.

recordings -- Captured audio files, in this case of parrot sounds.

analogous -- Similar in some way but not exactly the same.

cognitive -- Related to thinking, understanding, and processing information.

vocal skills -- The ability to produce and control sounds with the voice.

Background you need

Parrots are known for their vocal mimicry, but scientists have long debated whether they understand the words they repeat or just copy sounds.

PLOS ONE is a peer-reviewed scientific journal published by the Public Library of Science, covering all fields of science and known for open access.

The ManyParrots project is a citizen-science initiative that collects data on pet parrot behavior and vocalizations from owners worldwide, providing researchers with a large dataset.

Previous research has shown name-like calls in dolphins and some primates, but evidence for referential communication (using a sound to point to a specific individual) in parrots has been limited.

Break it down

LEAD: Parrots may use names in ways similar to humans, not just mimicry.

+ SOURCE: Study published in PLOS ONE based on ManyParrots project data.

METHOD: Analyzed 413 recordings from 889 parrots; looked for cases where a name was used only when a specific person or animal was present.

+ EXAMPLE: A parrot said 'John' only when John entered the room.

+ CAUTION: Researchers stressed we cannot yet call them names analogous to human names.

FINDINGS: Parrots also used their own name to attract attention, showing flexibility in name use for different social purposes.

+ IMPLICATION: Suggests parrots have cognitive abilities and vocal skills for referential communication.

OPEN QUESTION: How much intent is behind the signals? The line between mimicry and meaningful communication is blurring.

Why it matters

This research challenges our assumptions about animal intelligence, showing that parrots may understand and use language in more complex ways than we think--which can change how we treat and interact with pets and wild animals.

Test what you remember

1. What was the source of the data for the study on parrots?
 - (A) Wild parrot recordings in rainforests
 - (B) The ManyParrots project collecting surveys and audio from owners
 - (C) Zoo observations
 - (D) Laboratory experiments with captive parrots
2. How many cases showed parrots using a name as a label for a specific person or animal?
 - (A) 88
 - (B) 413
 - (C) 889
 - (D) 200
3. What did some parrots do when they said their own name?
 - (A) They asked for food.
 - (B) They attracted attention, like a child shouting 'Look at me!'
 - (C) They warned of danger.
 - (D) They repeated it when alone.
4. What did the researchers say about whether parrot names are analogous to human names?
 - (A) They concluded they are exactly the same.
 - (B) They cautioned we cannot fully conclude that yet.
 - (C) They proved parrots have human-like language.
 - (D) They said it's impossible to test.
5. Which university is Christine Dahlin from?
 - (A) University of Northern Colorado
 - (B) University of Pittsburgh at Johnstown
 - (C) Osaka Metropolitan University
 - (D) Tsinghua International School
6. What does the study suggest about parrot communication beyond mimicry?
 - (A) Parrots only copy sounds.
 - (B) Parrots may use names in social ways, possibly even referring to someone not present.
 - (C) Parrots cannot learn new names.
 - (D) Parrots only use names for themselves.

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: A 3: B 4: B 5: B 6: B

1. **Positive / Benefit:** The study provides compelling evidence that parrots can use sounds referentially, opening doors to understanding animal cognition and improving enrichment for captive birds.
2. **Negative / Critical:** The data came from pet owners, which may introduce bias. Controlled experiments are needed to confirm that parrots truly understand names as labels.
3. **Neutral / Analytical:** The findings align with known behaviors in other vocal learners like dolphins and songbirds, supporting the idea that referential communication evolved independently in multiple species.
4. **Forward-looking:** Future studies using video analysis and AI could decode parrot vocalizations in real time, revealing the full complexity of their social interactions and possibly allowing two-way communication.